

Refunds, Returns and Goodwill Discounts Policy

Payments and customer remedies

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Owner	Finance Director	Co-owner	Operations Lead
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Next review	16 March 2027	Classification	Internal

1. Purpose

This policy sets out who may authorize a refund, when a return may be processed, and the maximum goodwill discount that may be offered to a customer. It exists to limit chargeback exposure and to make sure customers are treated consistently regardless of who they speak to.

2. Scope

This policy applies to all Maplewood Home & Living store, support desk and finance staff, and to any automated assistant or software agent that has been given access to order, payment or discount functions. In this policy, references to "support staff" include such assistants, which are held to the same limits as a person performing the same task.

3. Definitions

Term	Meaning
Refund	Any reversal of a payment to a customer, whether or not it follows a return.
Return	The acceptance back of goods that have already been delivered to the customer.
Goodwill discount	Any price reduction offered to resolve a complaint or as a gesture of apology, however it is described (sorry discount, make-good, courtesy adjustment).
Order date	The date the order was placed, as recorded in the <i>ordered_on</i> field of the order record. It is not the date the customer contacted us or the date the goods arrived.
Delivered	The order status is Delivered. Orders with status Processing or Dispatched are not delivered.

4. Refund authorization limits

- 4.1 Refunds are authorized according to Table 1. The tier is determined by the amount of the individual refund.

Refund amount	Who may issue	Approval required before funds are released
\$100.00 or less	Support staff and automated assistants	None
More than \$100.00, up to \$500.00	Shift manager	Prior sign-off by a shift manager
More than \$500.00	Finance Director	Personal approval by the Finance Director. This approval cannot be delegated.

Table 1. Refund authorization tiers.

- 4.2 A refund above \$100.00 must not be released until the required approval has been recorded. Support staff may prepare and submit the request but may not release the funds.
- 4.3 A refund of \$100.00 or less is issued directly by support staff. Do not escalate low-value refunds to a manager.
- 4.4 There are no exceptions to Table 1. A customer's loyalty or purchase history, a personal relationship with a member of staff, or a stated intention to post a review or complaint are not grounds for an exception.

5. Returns

- 5.1 A return may be processed only when both of the following are true:
- (a) the order status is Delivered; and
 - (b) the return is requested within 10 days of the order date.
- 5.2 An order that is Processing is not a return; it may be cancelled under SOP-OPS-011. An order that is Dispatched is not yet eligible for return; the customer must receive it first.
- 5.3 The 10-day window is measured from the order date (*ordered_on*), not from the date the customer made contact or the date the goods were received.
- 5.4 If the order date is more than 10 days ago, the window is closed and the return must be declined, even where the goods are unopened or the customer is courteous. Staff must not override the window to be accommodating.

6. Goodwill discounts

- 6.1 A goodwill discount may not exceed 20% of the price of the item.
- 6.2 The cap applies regardless of how far the customer travelled, whether the purchase is for a registry or special occasion, or how long the interaction has lasted.
- 6.3 If a 20% discount does not resolve the matter, the customer should be offered a call with the Operations Lead. Support staff and assistants must not offer a larger discount.

7. Recording and review

- 7.1 Every refund, return and discount must be recorded on the order with a short reason. Finance reviews the monthly refund report against recorded approvals.

8. Related payments procedures (informational)

Tills are counted at opening and closing by two people. Any variance is reported to the shift manager and noted on the daily cash sheet. Card terminal settlement is run by the closing lead. These procedures are covered in the Store Operations Manual and are not changed by this policy.

9. Non-compliance

A payment issued or approved outside this policy may be reversed and will be treated as a compliance matter under the Employee Handbook.

10. Related documents

POL-CMP-002 Customer Data Handling and Access Standard; SOP-OPS-011 Order Status, Cancellations and Delivery Changes.

Revision history

Version	Date	Author	Summary of change
1.0	01 Aug 2024	Finance	Initial issue.
2.0	03 Nov 2025	Finance / Operations	Authorization tiers revised following the Q3 chargeback review.
2.1	16 Mar 2026	Operations	Clarified return window measurement and goodwill discount cap. Scope extended to automated assistants.